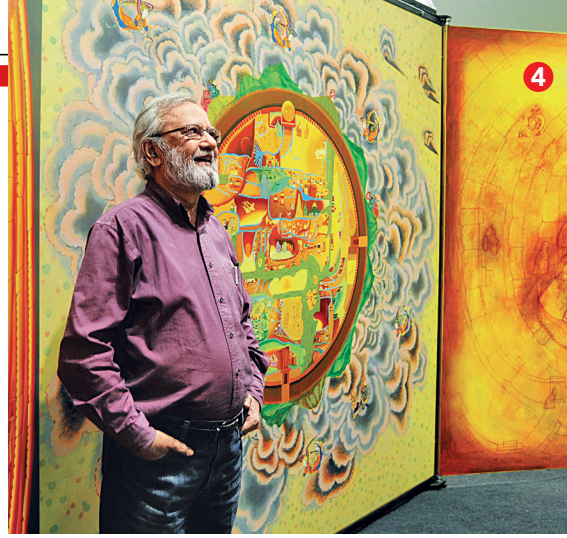
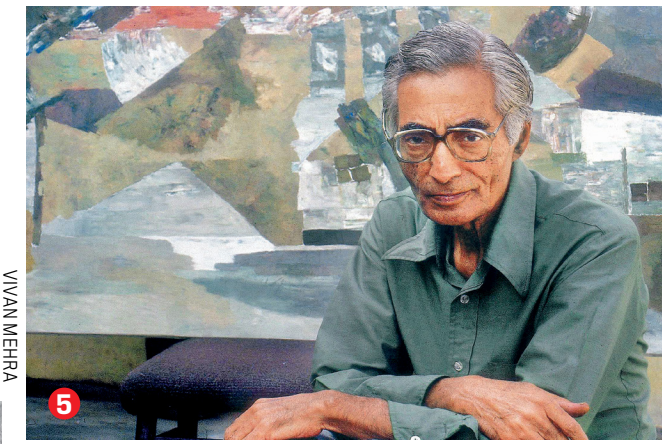




VIVAN MEHRA

YASBANT NEGI





GETTY IMAGES



1. **M.F. Husain** *(1915-2011)*

2. **Francis Newton Souza** *(1924-2002)*

3. **S.H. Raza** *(1922-2016)*

4. **Gulammohammed Sheikh** *(1937–)*

5. **Ram Kumar** *(1924-2018)*

team from all historical players—calculated only to provoke outrage at one's exclusions, with no points scored for the unavoidable inclusions. Following that spirit, we might ask, what are the specialist skills we must ensure are covered? In the field of visual art, what talents must our dream team, between them, possess?

First up, we need as captain the charismatic showman, the master of spin, if you will. That immediately brings in **M.F. Husain** (1915-2011), who held a line—in more senses than one—for over 60 years, and knew how to sell himself so well that he can now never be dethroned. Next up, we need the Bad Boy, the rebel out of control. Despite a crowd of also-rans, **Francis Newton Souza** (1924-2002) leads the pack. You may lament that his rebellion was personal and not political, and deplore his vision of women, but for pure savagery, he is unsurpassed. Violence was a condition of modernity in the last century. So too was the position of the émigré. You might object that we already have the émigré covered with our first two players, but Souza was a restless one, and Husain reluctant. For the quiet migrant who engaged with his host country without losing his sense of origins, we need **S.H. Raza** (1922-2016), the repetitive Tantric Monet of the Cote d'Azure.

Besides showing us the world anew, what else can art do? Well, it tells stories. No longer the old, familiar sacred tales with fixed iconographies that we are taught, but rather the personal, half-remembered anecdotes we are half-invited to share. As with the other roles, there are a host of contenders, but I choose **Gulammohammed Sheikh** (1937—), mainstay of the Baroda School. Closer to the spiritual domain is the ascetic, who makes icons to aid our meditation. Many would choose an abstractionist for this purpose, to avoid the noisy distraction of things; but I prefer to meditate in nature, and so I select the nearly abstract landscapes of **Ram Kumar** (1924-2018). Like terrains surveyed at dawn, his images keep us guessing, inquisitively exploring.

Another significant change since 1947 is diversity: caste, sexuality, and, most importantly, the emergence of women artists in strength and number. Objecting to their exclusion would certainly be justified. Some find it problematic to treat them as a category, since we do not speak of 'men artists'. Is it reasonable to expect a distinctive—more feminine—view of the world from a woman artist? My view is that we have no right to demand it, but we might get it regardless, because